

**UZBEKISTAN**

Capital city: Tashkent
Area: 172,741 sq miles (447,400 sq km)
Population: 26,100,000
Official language: Uzbek
Major religions: Muslim 88%, Christian 9%, other 3%
Government: Presidential dictatorship
Currency: Som
Adult literacy rate: 99%
Life expectancy: 67 years
People per doctor: 345

TAJIKISTAN

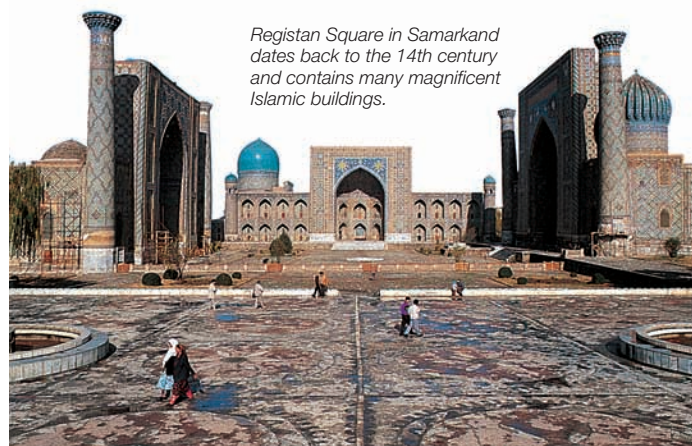
Capital city: Dushanbe
Area: 55,251 sq miles (143,100 sq km)
Population: 6,200,000
Official language: Tajik
Major religions: Muslim 85%, other 15%
Government: Democracy
Currency: Somoni
Adult literacy rate: 99%
Life expectancy: 70 years
People per doctor: 476

UZBEKISTAN

UZBEKISTAN IS THE MOST DENSELY POPULATED country in central Asia. It also has a varied landscape. While two-thirds of the land is made up of desert and arid steppe land, there are also fertile areas, fast-flowing rivers, and snowy mountaintops. The ancient cities of the Silk Road are beginning to attract ever increasing numbers of tourists, and foreign investors are helping develop the country's huge mineral and energy resources. Uzbekistan is also the world's fifth largest producer of cotton, known locally as "white gold."

ISLAMIC CITIES

The Silk Road is an old trading route that linked China with central Asia, the Middle East, and Europe. Ancient Islamic cities, once major trading centers, are found along its route. These include Samarkand, which contains many fine examples of Islamic architecture, Bukhara, an important place of pilgrimage for Muslims, and Tashkent, the capital of Uzbekistan, known as the "city of fountains."



Registan Square in Samarkand dates back to the 14th century and contains many magnificent Islamic buildings.

NATURAL GAS

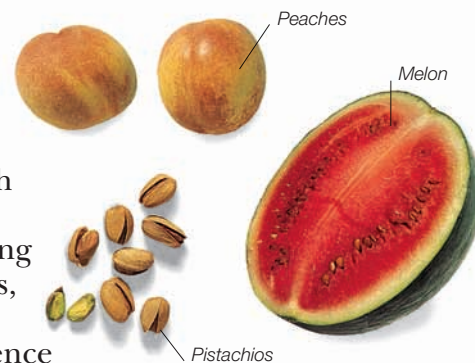
Uzbekistan is rich in natural resources. It has plentiful supplies of oil, natural gas, coal, gold, and uranium. A huge pipeline used for exporting natural gas stretches from Bukhara to the Urals in Russia. Much of the local industry, producing machinery, chemicals, and aircraft, is based on energy from gas.

TAJIKISTAN

THE POOREST OF THE FORMER SOVIET UNION states, Tajikistan is a mountainous country with only about six percent of its land available for farming. Most people work on the land, growing fruit, cotton, and tobacco and herding animals, or work in small factories producing textiles, silk, and carpets. From independence in 1991 until 1997, Tajikistan was split by armed conflict between the government and rebel groups.

PAMIR VALLEY PEOPLES

Less than 100,000 people live in the Pamir mountain region, growing grain and fruit in the deep valleys, or herding sheep and yaks on the bleak high plains in the east. Because of the remoteness of the area and the isolation of the valleys from each other, there is a bewildering variety of peoples, languages, and dialects.



FERTILE VALLEYS

In spring, melted snow from the Tien Shan and Pamir mountains flows down into the Fergana and other river valleys of Tajikistan, bringing with it rich, fertile mud. Irrigation channels direct this water into the surrounding fields, enabling farmers to grow a variety of crops, such as those above.

Find out more

COTTON: 36, 215, 216

GAS: 198, 211

ISLAM: 275

ISLAMIC ARCHITECTURE: 155

In the Pamir mountain region, a different tribal group is found in almost every valley.

